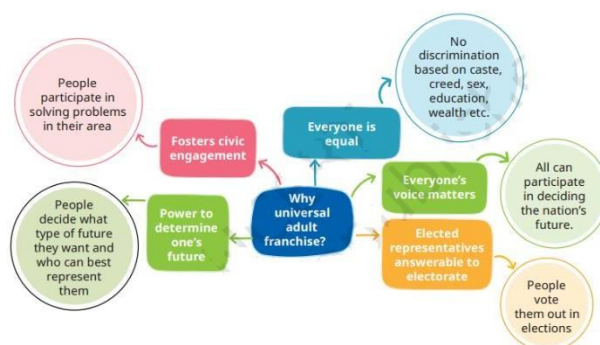


Chapter – 5: Universal Franchise and India's Electoral System

[India] adopted the principle of adult franchise with an abundant faith in the common man and the ultimate success of democratic rule...never before in the history of the world has such an experiment been so boldly undertaken.” – Alladi Krishnaswami Ayyar, November 1949, Constituent Assembly Debates

Universal Adult Franchise

- Constitution makers – decide – universal adult **franchise** – feature – Indian democracy – very beginning
- It means – every adult citizen – 1 vote – all votes – equal value
- Every Indian citizen – age – 18 and above – right to vote – irrespective – cast, creed, race, religion, gender, education, income
- Universal franchise – cornerstone – Indian democracy
- Elections – Lok Sabha, legislative assembly – every state, union territory – all local elections – villages, cities – based – universal franchise – Article 326 – Constitution
- Remember – no one – vote – another's behalf
- Able – exercise right – registered as voter – your **constituency**
- Someone – guilty – committing certain serious crimes – barred from voting
- India – gen. election – summer 2024
- 980 million voters – eligible – exercise franchise – 543 constituencies – Lok Sabha
- We need – elaborate, well-organized sys. – manage – massive exercise – ensure – elections – fairly, freely
- This chapter – brief exploration – who votes – few types of election – electoral **system** – how to organise
- Several reasons – universal franchise – so imp. – few – illustrated – mind map –



Bridging Barriers, Enabling Participation: Ensuring Universal Franchise

- Democracy – thrive – every citizen – eligible – free, fair participation – electoral process
- Voting – elections – powerful way – people – express will
- India – large, diverse, complex – population – Indian voters – 15x – population – United Kingdom – in terms – area – India – 6x – France
- Geographic diversity – challenge too – elections – India – organised – keeping complexity – in control
- Election Commission – India – organise elections
- ECI – several innovative measures – remove barriers – exercise franchise – ensure – no voter – left behind
- Electoral officials – travel – remote locations – ensure – every citizen – exercise – democratic rights
- 2024 – 1st time – elderly, disabled people – vote from home – postal voting options – available – specific category – voters
- Assistive tech. – braille voter cards – app-based requests – assistance – wheelchairs, ramps – also available
- **Election for class representative – Grade 8, Suryodaya School**
 - Time – annual election – class representative – class rep

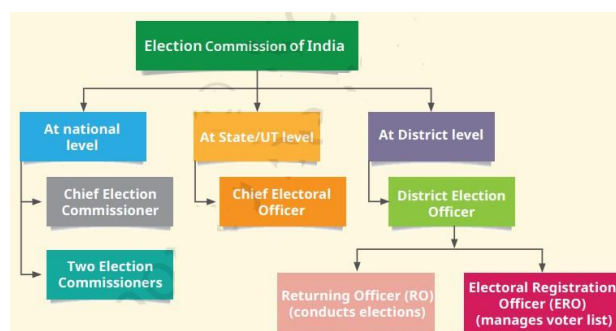
- Class rep – represent class – meetings – teachers – organise events – act – bridge – students, school authorities
- 3 students – Ahmed, Gurmat, Ravi – contest
- Class teacher – Ms. Usha – appointed – election officer – ensure – election process – fair, transparent
- Brief intro. – each candidate –
 - Ahmed – promised – improve – cleanliness – classrooms, playground
 - Gurmat – interested – helping – classmates – learn better – proposed – creating sys. – peer coaching – mutual support
 - Ravi – wanted – more space – class timetable – arts curriculum – music, theatre, visual art – a/c. – new curriculum
- **Campaigning**
 - Ahmed – put up posters – Gurmat – used noticeboard – spoke – classmates – Ravi – lunchtime music performance – promote idea
 - Election officer – Ms. Usha – organise elections – ensure – fair conduction
 - Explained rules – class – ensure – everyone understood – secret ballot voting – works
 - No one – knew – who voted – whom – ensure – process – private, fair
 - Set up – voting booth – corner – classroom
- **Voting day**
 - Election day – each student – ballot paper – names – 3 candidates
 - Student – asked – mark X – name of candidate – vote for
 - Ms. Usha – also ensure – ballot paper – braille – Neha
 - All students – vote – Ms. Usha – collect ballot – box – sealed – counting session
- **The results**
 - All 33 votes – cast – Ms. Usha – called Ms. Sheeba – next class – witness – counting
 - One ballot – not marked – declared invalid
 - Results – announced – Ahmed – 8 votes – Gurmat – 12 votes – Ravi – 10 votes
 - Gurmat – most votes – declared – class rep
 - Thanked classmates – promise – fulfil commitments
 - Ahmed, Ravi – congratulate her – offered support

The Role of the Election Commission of India (ECI)

- We saw – size, diversity – keep in mind – organisation – election process – India
- This section – we look – diff. types – elections – ECI – organise, oversee
- Here – only 2 elections – ECI manage – see more – later sections
- Before – get glimpse – election process – get intro. – Election Commission – India – institution – oversees election

Election Commission of India – a brief introduction

- ECI – independent body – responsible – conduct – free, fair elections
- Estd. – 1950 – elections – Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, State Legislative Assembly, offices – President, Vice President – India
- 1st gen. elections – independent India – 1951-1952



Managing the electoral process

- Managing elections – India – mammoth task
- ECI – keeps upgrading – capacities – match pace – needs – modern India – conduct – free, fair elections
- Electoral sys. – massive – needs to work efficiently
- Ex. – Lok Sabha elections – illustrate this – note – elections – state assemblies – same procedure
- All elections – diff. times – same periodicity – every yr. – several polls – various parts – country – when due
- Voters – 980 million – parliament constituencies – 543 – polling stations – 1 million+
- Obs. – no. – very large – many people – assist – whole process – even teachers
- Process – voting – Lok Sabha, state assemblies –
 - 1st – polling officer – checks name – voter list, ID
 - 2nd – polling officer – inks finger – takes sign.
 - 3rd – polling officer – checks finger
 - 4th – press button to vote – electronic voting machine (EVM) – hear beep – also check – printed slip – VVPAT

Model Code of Conduct (MCC)

- Code – followed – ensure – free, fair elections – list – do's, don'ts – leaders, political parties, candidates – must adhere
- Few elements of code –
 - Rules – party – govt. – follow – ensure – resources – available to govt. – not used – elections – ex. – no new schemes, projects – announced – may influence voters
 - All candidates – expected – exercise – discretion, restraint – ensure – elections – peaceful
 - Influence voters – gifts – votes – punishable

Understanding Elections in India – A Very Brief Overview**Election to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies**

- Elections – India – referred as – festival of democracy – time – citizens – exercise right – choose representatives – free, fair, responsible
- We know – India – parliamentary sys. – govt. – citizens – participate – various levels – elections – Lok Sabha – national – state assemblies – state – local bodies – city, village
- Country – divided – 543 constituencies – Lok Sabha elections
- Elected candidates – Lok Sabha – **Members of Parliament** (MPs) – elected candidates – state assemblies – **Members of Legislative Assembly** (MLAs)
- India – First-Past-the-Post – electoral sys. – candidate – max. votes – constituency – wins
- Meaning – candidate – win – without 50% votes – Gurmat – won – only 12 / 33 votes
- Voting process – complete – process – govt. formation – begins
- Political party – **coalition** – majority seats – Lok Sabha – national govt.
- Leader – majority – prime minister – state level – leader – majority – chief minister
- State Election Commission – part – election apparatus
- Imp. role – gen., state elections – BUT also – local bodies – grassroots level
- Works – consultation – ECI – these matters – universal adult franchise – other constitutional provisions – applicable – direct elections – pertinent – here as well

Election to the Rajya Sabha

- Candidates – elected – Rajya Sabha – Members of Parliament (MPs) – BUT – **indirect elections**

- Revisit – ex. – Suryodaya School – imagine – school – setting up – special council – school level – members – this council – selected by class reps – indirect elections
- 245 members – Rajya Sabha – 233 – elected by – MLAs – President – nominates – other 12
- Each state – diff. no. – seats – a/c. – population
- Ex. – more populous states – Uttar Pradesh – more seats – less populous states – Arunachal Pradesh – less seats
- Rajya Sabha – permanent House – never **dissolved**
- Member – Rajya Sabha – 6 yr. term – 1/3rd members – retire – every 2 yrs. – new ones – elected
- Voting process – diff. – Rajya Sabha – **single transferable vote system** – special way – ensure – smaller states – fair representation – Rajya Sabha – exact mechanism – higher classes

Election of the President of India

- **President of India** – not direct elections – common people – instead – electoral college – formed – carry out – election
- Electoral college –
 - MPs – both houses – Lower House (Lok Sabha), Upper House (Rajya Sabha)
 - MLAs – each Indian state – union territories – Delhi, Puducherry
- Single transferable vote system – followed – this election
- President – represent – entire country – this method – ensure – support – both – central, state govt.
- Rules – voting, counting – very elaborate – more populous states – greater say
- Following grp. of people – **not involved** – electing President –
 - Nominated members – Rajya Sabha – 12
 - Nominated members – State Legislative Assemblies
 - Members – Legislative councils – both – elected, nominated – **bicameral legislatures**
 - Nominated members – union territories – Delhi, Puducherry
- This ensure – directly elected representatives – vote – elect President
- Maintain – democratic legitimacy – President – represent will – people – indirectly – BUT – meaningfully

Election of the Vice President of India

- Vice President – India – elected – electoral college – elected, nominated members – both houses – single transferable vote sys. – used
- Vice president – chairperson – Rajya Sabha – situations – President – not able – discharge func. – vice president – steps in

Challenges and the Road Ahead

- India's electoral sys. – celebrated – world's largest democratic exercise
- BUT – like other sys. – own share – challenges
- Issues – growing influence – money – significant proportion – candidates – criminal records – voter apathy – raise ques. – health, future – democracy
- Way forward – empower voters – info. – needed – make responsible choices
- Media, education, awareness campaign – work together – help people – especially youth – understand imp. – wise voting
- Aware, vigilant voter – strongest safeguard – democratic sys.
- Starts – asking – right ques. – ends – responsible vote